rifles. Captain Saxena was recovered by another Sikh LI patrol with severe frostbite on his toes.

1 Sikh sent out a five-man patrol under a JCO towards Lunguthang. They returned and reported no Chinese activity. This was then followed up by another platoon of 1 Sikh on 7 November. This patrol reported more than 500 Chinese troops in the area. The Chinese in the meantime outflanked the patrol and a 200-strong force intercepted the Sikhs near Dzalung-la. Fortunately, 2 Sikh LI mortars firing from Kye-la managed to help extricate the patrol.

Three days later, on 10 November, 4 Garhwal Ops reported a large body of yaks and mules on the move between Rho and Melling. As day gave way to night, reports started coming in of a large number of Chinese having concentrated near 1 Sikh. A Chinese jitter party, which had clambered up an adjoining hill, fired a burst. The Sikhs, unsure of the direction of attack, opened up with small arms and mortars. The field guns, not to be left out, joined in. However, all the firing was at nothing and lasted close to two hours before the officers could bring the situation under control. The panicky reaction of the troops and expending of precious ammunition was a clear indication that the troops on Se-la Top were beginning to get edgy.

While the guns were blazing against an imagined enemy on Se-la, observation posts at Nuranang could see headlights winding their way down towards Tawang from the direction of Bum-la. The road that the Chinese had been constructing had obviously been opened.

Kaul’s belief that the Chinese would be quite content to sit out the winter south of the Tawang Chu turned out to be misplaced. Increased Chinese activity in the last few days coupled with 1 Sikh’s panic reaction the previous evening did not augur well for the brigade’s fighting capabilities.

On 11 and 12 November, alarming reports started coming in from 4 Garhwal Rifles that a large body of Chinese troops—estimated to be in the region of a thousand—were moving from Rho towards Melling in small parties of twenty to thirty men. General Pathania, perhaps influenced by the overreaction by 1 Sikh on Se-la Top, scoffed at the ‘impossibility’ of the information. The reconnaissance carried out by Brigadier Palit’s DQ two years previously had estimated that the Bailey Trail that bypassed Se-la from the east could at best be negotiated by a party of company strength. No one since had questioned this reasoning. Obviously where sixty men